for Patna, for which offence Muzaffar Khan was expelled from the expedition.

In short, Muzaffar Khan had not had the smoothest of career graphs, but he had found something of a second wind in the east.

Here, working independently of Akbar's 'official' conquest of Bengal and Bihar, which was headed by Munim, Muzaffar Khan had made great efforts to regain Akbar's favour, including a valiant if unsuccessful bid for Rohtas fort, and an impressive victory against an Afghan army in Bihar, for which Akbar gave him Hajipur.

Munim Khan, unhappy with the sudden return to favour of his erstwhile underling, wanted Muzaffar gone, but Akbar was pleased with his accountant's performance on the battlefield and ordered him to remain. Muzaffar Khan settled down to feast on the fruits of his success. He 'came to Hajipur', writes Abul Fazl, 'and spread the carpet of enjoyment' – little knowing how the rug would be snatched from under his feet.

Munim, meanwhile, settled in Gaur, the old capital of Bengal, at the very time that the city was afflicted by a plague. '*Az Gaur ba gor*' is how Nizamuddin describes the devastation – from Gaur to the grave. His officers begged to leave the city for the newer capital, Tanda, but Munim wouldn't budge. Maybe he knew something the others did not: though corpses were being chucked out of Gaur into the river outside, Munim remained immune to 'that typhoon of plague'.[6] It was only when he did finally move to Tanda that Munim caught 'a little illness'.[7]

Munim Khan had lived a long life. Perhaps, in these last ten days of it he remembered how Humayun had come chasing after him as he tried to abandon the destitute padishah; perhaps he remembered sitting mid-river with Ali Quli Shaibani, shedding nostalgic tears for Humayun's death. Perhaps he remembered letting Akbar skip school to fly his pigeons and was amazed, one last time, at what a formidable man that restless boy had become. Or perhaps it was not Akbar's childhood Munim recalled, but his own – the crisp air and orchards of Kabul, as he breathed his last mouthfuls of rain-moist air by a river in Bengal.

On 27 October 1575, Munim Khan died. Two weeks later, the news of his death arrived in Fatehpur along with reports that Daud had reneged on his truce; there was 'great uneasiness' in the imperial army, its commanders